

Competency levels and how they are evidenced

The four-level scale, the evidence that moves a person up it, and the two other ladders it is not



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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

PCI describes competence on a four-point scale — foundation, practitioner, professional and leader — applied one competency at a time. This document defines each level by the decisions it carries rather than by adjectives, sets out the evidence hierarchy that moves a claim from assertion to demonstration, and separates the competency scale from the credential level and from the membership grades, which are different things that share vocabulary.

— About this document

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Competency levels and how they are evidenced

In one paragraph. PCI describes competence on a four-point scale — foundation, practitioner, professional and leader — applied one competency at a time. This document defines each level by the decisions it carries rather than by adjectives, sets out the evidence hierarchy that moves a claim from assertion to demonstration, and separates the competency scale from the credential level and from the membership grades, which are different things that unfortunately share vocabulary. After reading it you should be able to place a real person on the scale for a real competency and say what evidence would change your placement.

Who this is for. Line managers writing development plans and appraisals, candidates assembling a portfolio of evidence, and assessors who must apply one scale consistently across people they have never met.

— 1. Why levels have to be defined by decisions

Most competency scales fail in the same place. They are written with adjectives — "basic", "good", "strong", "expert" — and adjectives cannot be tested. Two managers rating the same person against "strong cost management" will disagree, discover they disagree only at moderation, and settle it by seniority rather than by evidence.

The scale below is written with **decisions and their consequences**. Each level answers four questions:

1. What does the person decide, and what do they escalate?
2. Who checks the output before it is relied upon?
3. What happens when the situation falls outside procedure?
4. Who carries the error when it turns out to be wrong?

Question four is the sharpest. It is possible to perform sophisticated work at practitioner level; what makes the level professional is that when the number is wrong, the professional is the one who has to explain why — and had the authority to make the choice that produced it.

— 2. The four levels

The scale applies to **one competency at a time**. A person is not "a practitioner"; a person is at practitioner level in planning and scheduling and at professional level in commercial and contract controls. Uneven profiles are the norm and carry the information that matters.

2.1 Foundation

Works within a defined procedure, on a defined part of the work, with the output checked before anyone relies on it. Uses the established method because it is the established method. Recognises

when something looks wrong and escalates rather than resolving it. The organisation carries the error.

The distinguishing test: can this person produce a correct output when the situation is normal?

2.2 Practitioner

Owens a defined scope end to end — a control account, a discipline schedule, a section of a financial model, a work package. The output is relied on without routine correction. Chooses between established methods where the procedure prescribes the choice, and applies the procedure to cases it plainly covers. Escalates the cases it does not.

The distinguishing test: does the work leave this person's hands in a state where the next person builds on it rather than checks it?

2.3 Professional

Decides the method where procedure is silent, and defends the decision to someone who wanted a different answer. Owns the number under challenge: can state the basis, the alternatives rejected, the sensitivity of the result to each assumption, and the point at which they would change their view. Detects and corrects error in other people's work, including work produced by a system. Sets the working standard for a team.

The distinguishing test: when the case is not covered by procedure and the answer is unwelcome, does this person produce a defensible position — and hold it for the right reasons and release it for the right reasons?

2.4 Leader

Sets the rule that others apply, across projects rather than within one. Accountable for the integrity of the system that produces the numbers, including when that system fails — which means owning the failure, diagnosing whether it was an individual error or a design fault, and changing the design. Decides where a method must **not** be used, including where an automated or AI-derived method must not be used, and carries the consequence of that decision. Builds capability deliberately, so that the function survives the departure of any individual.

The distinguishing test: if this person left, would the method survive them — and did they design it so that it would?

2.5 The verb grammar

Level descriptors throughout this series are written with a controlled vocabulary, so that a reader can tell the level from the verb even out of context.

Level	Verbs	Ownership of error
Foundation	assists · prepares · checks against a rule · escalates	The organisation
Practitioner	performs · owns a scope · applies · reconciles	The individual, within scope
Professional	decides · defends · challenges · corrects others	The individual, including the method
Leader	sets · governs · withholds · designs · answers for	The system and its failures

"Understands", "is familiar with", "is aware of" and "has exposure to" appear nowhere in this framework. They describe a mental state that no evidence can reach.

— 3. Three ladders that share vocabulary

This is the section to read twice, because the collisions are real and they mislead people about what they hold.

Ladder	What it measures	Values	Who assigns it
Competency level	Depth of capability in one named competency	foundation · practitioner · professional · leader	Assessment against evidence
Credential level	The positioning of a whole credential	Leader (all three PCI credentials)	The certification scheme
Membership grade	Standing within the Institute	SPCI · APCI · MPCl · FPCI	Membership rules

Credential level. All three credentials — PCL-AI, PFL-AI and PML-AI — are positioned at **Leader** level. That is a statement about the credential, not a claim that every holder is at leader level on every competency in its set. A credential samples a set of competencies and certifies that the holder met the standard on the sample; it does not certify a uniform ceiling.

A recorded inconsistency, stated rather than resolved. The platform database records all three credentials at level Leader. One public page ([certification.html](#)) renders the level as Professional. This series uses **Leader**, in line with the platform record, and treats the competency-scale word professional as an unrelated concept — a point on the scale in §2.3, never a credential position. The discrepancy is genuine and is logged rather than quietly corrected: [\[CONFIRM: single authoritative credential-level wording across platform database and public pages\]](#).

Membership grade. Student Member (SPCI), Associate Member (APCI), Professional Member (MPCI) and Fellow (FPCI) are standings within the Institute. Professional Member requires an active PCI certification; Fellow is by nomination. **A grade is not a competence measure and never evidences a competency.** The traps are specific and both directions occur: reading MPCI as "assessed at professional level" (it is not — it is a membership standing that happens to require a current certification), and reading FPCI as a superlative competence rating (it is a nomination-based standing recognising contribution). A fellow who has not earned a PCI credential holds no PCI certification.

— 4. The evidence hierarchy

A competency claim is worth what its evidence is worth. Evidence types are not interchangeable, and the ordering below is the one an assessor should apply when two sources conflict.

Rank	Evidence type	What it can show	What it cannot
1	An artefact you produced, dated, with your reasoning visible in it	Method choice, judgement under the conditions of the day	That you would repeat it under different conditions
2	An artefact you materially contributed to, with your contribution identifiable	Capability within a defined scope	Sole ownership, or the decisions someone else made
3	A structured professional discussion in which you are questioned on your own artefact	Depth behind the artefact; whether you can defend it	Anything the questioner did not think to probe
4	Direct observation of the work	Behaviour and interaction that artefacts never capture	Anything outside the observed period
5	Attestation by a named person with named standing who saw the work	Corroboration, scope, duration	Detail; and it inherits the attester's judgement
6	Examination performance	Applied knowledge and reasoning against a common standard	Whether the person does it under real pressure
7	Self-report	Where to look next	Capability. See §7 of CMP-10

Two practical rules follow.

Reasoning must be visible in the artefact, not reconstructed afterwards. A forecast that records the method used, the alternatives rejected and the assumption the answer hangs on is rank-1 evidence. The same forecast without that record is a number, and a number can be produced by a spreadsheet someone else built. The habit of writing the basis into the artefact at the time is the single cheapest thing a candidate can do to make their own competence provable later.

Contribution must be identifiable at the time, not asserted later. "I built the risk model" is uncheckable two years on. A model with a version history, a named owner per section, and an issue log carrying your name against specific resolutions is checkable.

— 5. Evidence by level

The type of evidence changes as the level rises, because the thing being demonstrated changes.

Level	What must be shown	Representative evidence
Foundation	Correct output under normal conditions, and escalation of the abnormal	Completed work to procedure; a raised query that turned out to be right; a checked-and-accepted deliverable
Practitioner	An owned scope, relied on without correction	A control account or model section you own; a month-end pack you produce; a reconciliation you sign
Professional	A defended decision where procedure was silent	A dated method-selection note; a forecast you revised upward against pressure, with the basis; a correction you made to a superior's number, and the outcome
Leader	A rule others apply, and accountability when it fails	A procedure or standard you authored and that is in use; a decision to withhold a method or tool, with reasoning; a post-incident change to the system after a failure you owned

Note the shape of professional-level evidence: it usually documents **friction**. If a candidate's entire portfolio is smooth — every forecast accepted, every position unchallenged — the portfolio is showing practitioner-level work performed pleasantly, or a professional whose contemporaneous record is missing. CMP-09 — Behavioural and leadership competencies covers what that friction looks like when handled well.

— 6. Currency: when evidence expires

Competence decays, and it decays unevenly. Judgement about contract mechanics survives a decade; fluency in a reporting toolchain or an AI-assisted method does not survive two years of disuse.

The Institute's working position:

- Evidence more than **three years** old is treated as historical. It supports a claim; it does not carry one alone. Three years is chosen deliberately to align with the certification cycle.
- Evidence for any competency naming AI, automation or digital delivery is treated as **fast-decaying**: the method changes, and unexercised familiarity is not capability. Recertification therefore carries a mandatory AI-currency component, and the platform's continuing professional development category satisfying it is named exactly that. CER-08 owns the recertification rules, including the binding continuing professional development requirement, which is not yet published [CONFIRM: binding CPD hours per three-year cycle — the student portal shows a 30-hour target, which is not a rule].
- A competency exercised on one project type only is evidenced for that context. Say so rather than generalising it; an assessor will find the boundary anyway, and finding it themselves costs the candidate credibility they did not need to lose.

— 7. How this goes wrong

Levels are assigned by seniority. A manager is rated professional because they are a manager. The rating then becomes unfalsifiable, because nobody is going to rate their own manager down, and the scale stops carrying information within a cycle.

One level is assigned to a whole person. The single most common misuse. It destroys the uneven profile, which is the actionable part: the person who is professional in earned value and foundation in automation has an obvious, cheap development plan, and "practitioner overall" hides it.

"Professional" is read as a rank rather than a scale point. Someone at professional level in three competencies believes they hold a professional standing, or believes they are equivalent to a Professional Member (MPCI). They are different ladders (§3). Where both appear in one document, label both.

Leader level is claimed for scope rather than for rule-setting. Managing thirty people is a span of control. Leader level requires that a method exists because you decided it should, that others apply it, and that you answered for it when it failed. Headcount is not evidence.

Evidence is gathered retrospectively at application time. The candidate reconstructs reasoning from memory, and the reconstruction is uniformly favourable, because nobody remembers the assumption they failed to test. This is not dishonesty; it is how memory works. The counter is contemporaneous recording, which costs a paragraph at the time.

A training certificate is filed as evidence of a competency. It evidences attendance. It becomes evidence of competency only when accompanied by work produced afterwards that the training explains.

Currency is never tested. A portfolio is accepted whole, including a demonstration from a project that closed six years ago, on a delivery model the organisation abandoned. Ask when, not just whether.

The scale is imported into pay banding unchanged. The moment a level determines a salary band, every rating conversation becomes a negotiation, evidence standards fall, and the framework's diagnostic value is gone. Use it for development and assessment; if it must inform reward, put a moderation step (CMP-10 §5) between the rating and the money.

— 8. Checklist

For a levelling conversation about a real person:

- [] Are we levelling **one competency at a time**, by name?
 - [] For each level claimed, which of the four questions in §1 have we actually answered — decision, check, procedure-silence, ownership of error?
 - [] Is the evidence rank 1 or 2 in §4, or are we leaning on rank 5–7?
 - [] Is the reasoning visible **inside** the artefact, or reconstructed in the conversation?
 - [] For a professional-level claim, can we point to a decision made where procedure was silent, and to how it was defended?
 - [] For a leader-level claim, can we name the rule, the people applying it, and a failure that was owned?
 - [] How old is the evidence, and does the competency decay fast (§6)?
 - [] Has anyone in the room used "professional" to mean the membership grade, or "leader" to mean seniority?
 - [] Would a second assessor, given the same folder and this document, reach the same level?
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— Related

- [CMP-01 – The PCI competency framework – overview](#) — what the sets are and how each competency is written
 - [CMP-03 – PCL-AI: the fourteen competencies](#) — the scale applied competency by competency
 - [CMP-09 – Behavioural and leadership competencies](#) — the behaviours that professional-level evidence usually documents
 - [CMP-10 – Assessing competence – evidence, rubrics and moderation](#) — rubric wording, scoring rules and moderation
 - [CAR-07 – Building a portfolio of evidence](#) — how a candidate assembles and dates the artefacts
 - [CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement](#) — the currency rules for a held credential
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— Sources and standards

- PCI platform certification catalogue (<backend/Data/MultiCert.cs>), verified August 2026 — the credential `level` field is recorded as Leader for PCL-AI, PFL-AI and PML-AI. The divergent Professional rendering on the public certification page is recorded in §3 as an open discrepancy.
- Membership grades and their requirements as published by the Institute: SPCI, APCI, MPCCI (requires an active PCI certification), FPCI (by nomination).
- ISO/IEC 17024, Conformity assessment — general requirements for bodies operating certification of persons. Referenced for the principle that competence must be defined before it is assessed and that assessment decisions must be documented and reviewable. Described in our own words; no text reproduced; PCI is not accredited to it.

— Status and version

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